

tool to help us plan, monitor and control the schedule very tightly. The total time taken for a project is based on the time taken for each task, and whether some of the tasks can be done side-by-side. Project management tools really help you to lay out all the tasks, their durations and whether some can be done only after the predecessor tasks are done. Helping you see the entire project at a glance with all these linkages built-in and visually laid out is the Gantt chart.

Train your team to take on bigger projects in future

To-do lists are fine for small tasks. You can keep adding to the list and keep checking off the ones completed. Spreadsheets may be OK for small, well-understood projects to be done by one or, possibly, a couple of people who have a track record of good coordination. Trying to manage anything beyond this using a spreadsheet is asking for trouble. If the high cost of project management software is what is holding you back, open source software can help.

Getting your team members to think in terms of predecessor and successor tasks, resource levelling, critical path, milestones and planned versus actual costs will train them and pay off when you have to take on larger projects. In other words, if the team talks project 'lingo', then it can communicate and coordinate more effectively. It can talk less and get more accomplished. With the help of a Gantt chart your team can develop a shared vision and work like a well-oiled machine.

Who needs to do what and in which sequence

Even if you are the only person who is going to do all the work for a project, it helps to plan ahead. But if there are more people involved, whether it be your own team members or even subcontractors, then some type of planning and keeping the team informed as to who is assigned to do what and

when is crucial. Otherwise, some number of tasks will be at risk of falling through the cracks. People will assume that someone else is doing a particular task and you will come to know of it only after the fact. More importantly, this will result in finger pointing and recrimination, spoiling the all important ingredient for project success -- teamwork and morale. Again an example will help. Let us say you have to install a new Web server. The tasks may be racking and stacking, connecting to the network, assigning an IP address, installing the OS, installing the Web server and hardening, namely, removing unneeded software and accesses, and changing default passwords. These tasks often have to be done by different people with the requisite skills and in a very specific sequence.

Eliminating teaser versions, freeware and abandonware

You are looking for an open source project management tool. How hard can it be? Just a quick Web search brings a ton of stuff. There is such a wide array of options; it should be easy to pick one, right? Unfortunately, that is not the case. Some of the articles mix fully open source software with teaser versions and freeware. Teaser versions are offered in what is known as the freemium business model. The entry-level features are often available in the free version. However, you may have to pay for the more advanced features. Nothing wrong with this model, except that you need to be aware of the limitations at the outset. Freeware may pose security risks and is very often offered in 'as is where is' condition. There may not be any user guide, or a mailing list or forum that you can fall back on to find out how others are using it. Other reviewers who focus on open source software sometimes include abandonware — software that have not seen an update or a bug fix in years. Once you filter out all those distractions, you will still be left with a handful of tools that serve different

types of project management, from which you have to figure out which one will best fit your needs.

In this series of articles we will simplify all of these for you by recommending a few select open source project management tools under the following four categories.

Part 1: Desktop project management tools like MS Project

Part 2: Project servers like MS Project Server

Part 3: Agile/Scrum software project management tools like Jira

Part 4: Kanban software project management tools like Trello

Desktop project management tools like MS Project

We feature only two tools in this category — ProjectLibre and GanttProject. Typical of most open source software, these two run on Linux, Windows as well as Mac operating systems. Either of these tools will help you to prepare a basic project plan. You can set up a calendar based on your working week and working hours as well as holidays. You can enter details about the resources that will be working on this project.

You enter the project start date, the tasks and their durations, assign the resources for each task and enter the predecessors for each task. Based on this input, the tool will calculate the start date and end date for each task. You can also create milestones, which is helpful for senior leadership to keep track of whether intermediate goals have been reached. You can create an initial baseline as well as other baselines when there are major changes to the project plan. This way you can prepare reports that compare the baseline with the progress of the actual project. When the project is progressing, you can update its status day-to-day by entering the percentage completion for each task. You can view the project as a PERT chart as well as create reports about tasks, resources, costs and project progress, and send those out in PDF or spreadsheet formats.